The Art *of* Surrender

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Blair Purvis

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Content Warning

This story includes themes of suicide and self harm.
If these topics are difficult for you,
please consider whether this book is right for you at this time.

Mature Content

Not suitable for younger readers.

For all the gay men we half lost to self-harm.

We who love you and miss you hold the other half here.

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Part One

The Ḥammām



1

The Wooden Door

The wooden door was ancient and heavy. Ayman pressed his shoulder into the time-weathered grain. It resisted, as though begging him to reconsider entering. The air inside was warmer than expected, heavy with the smell of saline, mould, and humidity. A woman dressed in black stood behind a broad wooden counter that marked the boundary between her world and the clientele's. She was tending to a short, grey-haired man in his sixties, portly, barefoot, and wrapped in a towel. Ayman stopped just inside the doorway. He could turn around now, and no one would think the lesser of him.

The woman's pen ran steadily down the open register. The older man leaned across the counter and protested in a hushed voice. She shook her head and flipped the page, checking each ledger entry with deliberate scrutiny. Ayman took a few steps forward, keeping a safe distance behind the man, who was becoming insistent. The Arabic sign above the woman in black read:

'Ḥammām de Maroc. Women: Sun, Mon, Tue; Men: Wed, Thu, Sat.'

It was the place he had come for, not the one the tourists were steered towards. They went up the road to the Portuguese Cistern; this ḥammām barely registered online, half-forgotten, its renovations stalled somewhere short of respectable. Ayman suspected that what the restoration budget could not provide, the ḥammām's reputation now quietly did.

Ayman had spent the last year imagining this moment in safer places. In the privacy of his bedroom, on late nights when sleep refused him, he had pictured encounters with faceless men, broad-shouldered, confident, and commanding, not portly and middle-aged. The ḥammām in his dreams did not smell of seawater. Of sweat, perhaps, but not like this.

Ayman wondered what he would say when it was his turn to be seen. He tried the phrases quietly in his head.

'Addēsh et-tazkara?'

'No, that sounds formal. Too formal.'

'What would they say here? The vowels heavier. The consonants swallowed. In Morocco, the words are different. Bshḥal not addēsh.'

Would they hear the Levant in him? Or the Llanito lilt in his English? Would they hear he did not quite belong anywhere?

He tried again. 'Ana… No, too stiff. Would she speak English? French? Plenty of tourists in El Jadida, so probably. Hopefully.'

The woman looked up from her register and acknowledged his presence with a nod, fixing him in place. The heavy door creaked open, and he heard the footsteps of a man joining the queue behind him.

He should have prepared properly. Entry fees? Towels? Protocol? Had he misunderstood everything, and was his kitchen-table Arabic sufficient to get answers?

The man at the counter was concluding his complaint; he was next in line. Ayman turned to leave.

Between Ayman and the door stood a man close to his own age, European in appearance with three-day stubble, denim shirt, and jeans, striking enough that Ayman's urge to leave faltered.